

Manual focus, manual settings for aperture size and shutter speed are some features you should definitely look out for.

Introduction

There's a fair share of terminologies you need to get familiar with, in order to get involved in digital cameras and photography. You will get a fair dose of it here. The aperture is the gap through which light enters the camera, and plays a major role on how much light is allowed. The aperture size is decided by the f number. The smaller the f number, the greater is the aperture size and vice-versa. Generally, a small aperture yields crisp images. The shutter speed, also, goes hand-in-hand with the aperture size to allow an optimum amount of light to enter the camera. The faster the shutter speed, the lesser the light that enters the camera and crisper are the resultant images. Some cameras even allow you to set a fixed aperture size or shutter speed while the camera adapts the other settings.



A higher ISO Rating adds a considerable amount of graininess to the photo

Exposure Metering Modes

Your digital camera senses light intensity in a scene and chooses the appropriate settings for it. In most cameras, there are multiple modes by which the camera can detect the surrounding light. This light measuring can be done through a single tiny spot in the centre or the entire screen. Sometimes, if only the centre of a scene is a bright colour—say someone's white shirt, then the camera might be fooled into thinking that the entire scene is well lit-up—the image, as a result might turn out pretty dark. In such cases, switching the exposure mode to screen mode can help, so that the entire view is evaluated for the surrounding lighting conditions and a more realistic and natural photo is captured.

White Balance

Each lighting source—a bulb, tubelight or the sun, for example—has a colour temperature. White Balance is a neglected option in the camera (yeah... the term sounds familiar!) and most people unknowingly continue using Auto White Balance. AWB chooses a white balance, which it thinks suits the scene. The camera gets it wrong a lot of times and photos then end up with an odd colour tint. You can get awesome results by simply selecting the appropriate white balance for the type of lighting you are in. Selecting from among the pre-defined profiles given with your camera, changes a lot of other

unrelated settings. Therefore, take some time out to go through the menus and set a suitable white balance before taking a shot... err... in the dark! D-SLR users on the other hand have the freedom to change the white balance of a photo after it has been shot—thanks to RAW—data which you can read about later in this story.

Focus Modes

Cameras today come with focus modes meant to improve on the autofocus features seen in all P&S cameras. Some cameras come with multi-spot focussing features, which focus on multiple spots or jump spots in a scene. This way, the user loses control over what's constantly in focus. You should, therefore, ensure the use of the centre focus or the spot focus, which focuses on a small spot at the centre of the scene. This ensures that whatever you're pointing the camera at, comes out perfectly in focus. If you want to focus on something that's not at the centre, then point the camera at the subject and half press the trigger button then point the camera anywhere you wish. When ready, complete the click to take the shot. If your P&S camera has a manual focus, then you get increased flexibility and your shoots yield amazingly professional results.

ISO Rating

The ISO ratings in a camera are related to the sensitivity of the sensor. They're considered similar to the film speed on film cameras. Changing the ISO ratings is useful for low light situations or to get the best quality images. Dropping the ISO number to the least possible value, say, ISO 100 or ISO 80 will get the best quality out of a sensor. However, this requires a well lit up scene and is best for studio light setups or broad daylight. On the other hand, for darker places, increasing the ISO number will help but images will turn out grainy. For best results in such cases, a good balance between the ISO ratings, aperture size and shutter speed is required.

Flash Settings

Cameras have some control over the intensity of the flash used. The Fill in flash mode is a moderately powerful flash that is used to add some lighting in darker areas. This is useful when your subjects have a shadow cast on their face and the filling light can illuminate such areas. The other option for the flash that you might find is the Slow Sync mode. This mode is especially useful in poorly lit up areas, where the flash is required. The Slow Sync feature allows some detail to be added to the shot where a normal flash would result in sharp shadows and everything beyond the target to be completely



What is RAW and why the fuss?

A RAW image is an untreated or uncompressed file that is usually found on D-SLR's and many choose to call it the D-SLR's equivalent of a negative film. Changes, if required, can be done through software that can handle RAW images like Photoshop for example. The unfortunate part is that P&S cameras don't support RAW files. In general, these are much larger than JPEGs. RAW is of utmost most significance for the professionals.